三国的故事

历史和小说

The Three Kingdoms

History and the Novel

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 4 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 在中国，几乎每个人都知道“三国”[1]的故事。三国指的是魏[2]、蜀[3]、吴[4]三个国家，它们在公元3世纪的时候同时存在，互相打仗[5]，一直打了几十年。这段历史不到一百年，可是它留下的故事比很多更长的朝代[6]还要多。

2 为什么会这样呢？一个重要的原因是一本书。大约六百多年前，作家罗贯中[7]写了一本长篇小说，叫《三国演义》[8]。这本小说非常好看，人物[9]特别有意思，所以很多人都读过，或者在电视和戏曲[10]里看过。不过，小说毕竟[11]是小说。真正的历史主要记录在另一本书[12]里，就是西晋[13]的历史学家陈寿[14]写的《三国志》[15]。

1 三国 *Sānguó* the Three Kingdoms
2 魏 *Wèi* Wei (kingdom)
3 蜀 *Shǔ* Shu (kingdom)
4 吴 *Wú* Wu (kingdom)
5 打仗 *dǎzhàng* to fight a war
6 朝代 *cháodài* dynasty
7 罗贯中 *Luó Guànzhōng* Luo Guanzhong (c. 1330–1400), novelist
8 三国演义 *Sānguó Yǎnyì* Romance of the Three Kingdoms (novel)
9 人物 *rénwù* characters, figures
10 戏曲 *xìqǔ* traditional opera
11 毕竟 *bìjìng* after all
12 另 *lìng* another
13 西晋 *Xī Jìn* Western Jin dynasty (265–316)
14 陈寿 *Chén Shòu* Chen Shou (233–297), historian
15 三国志 *Sānguó Zhì* Records of the Three Kingdoms (history)

In China almost everyone knows the stories of the "Three Kingdoms". The 1
Three Kingdoms were Wei, Shu and Wu, three states that existed side by side in the third century AD and fought one another for decades. This period lasted less than a hundred years, yet it has left behind more stories than many much longer dynasties.

Why is that? One important reason is a book. About six hundred years ago 2
the writer Luo Guanzhong wrote a long novel called Romance of the Three Kingdoms. The novel is a great read and its characters are wonderfully vivid, so a great many people have read it, or seen it on television or on the opera stage. But a novel is, after all, a novel. The real history is recorded mainly in another book, the Records of the Three Kingdoms, written by the Western Jin historian Chen Shou.

下面我们就来讲几个最有名的三国[1]故事，同时看一看哪些是历史，哪些是小说家加上去的。

天下[2]大乱

东汉[3]末年，皇帝[4]的权力[5]越来越小，朝廷[6]里很乱，老百姓的生活也很苦。公元 184 年，发生了黄巾[7]起义，全国到处都在打仗[8]。为了打败起义军[9]，各地的将军[10]都有了自己的军队[11]。起义失败以后，这些将军却不再[12]听皇帝的话，开始互相抢[13]地盘。

在这些人里，最有能力的是曹操[14]。

1 三国 *Sānguó* the Three Kingdoms
2 天下 *tiānxià* the whole country
3 东汉 *Dōng Hàn* Eastern Han dynasty (25–220)
4 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
5 权力 *quánlì* power
6 朝廷 *cháotíng* imperial court
7 黄巾 *Huángjīn* Yellow Turbans
8 打仗 *dǎzhàng* to fight a war
9 起义军 *qǐyìjūn* rebel army
10 将军 *jiāngjūn* general
11 军队 *jūnduì* army
12 不再 *bùzài* no longer
13 抢 *qiǎng* to seize
14 曹操 *Cáo Cāo* Cao Cao (155–220), warlord of the north

Below we tell a few of the most famous Three Kingdoms stories, and at the same time look at which parts are history and which were added by the novelist. 2

An Empire Falls Apart

In the last years of the Eastern Han, the emperor's power kept shrinking, the court was in disorder, and ordinary people lived hard lives. In 184 AD the Yellow Turban uprising broke out, and there was fighting all over the country. To defeat the rebels, generals everywhere raised armies of their own. After the uprising failed, these generals no longer obeyed the emperor and began seizing territory from one another. 3

Of all these men, the most capable was Cao Cao. 4

4 他控制[1]了北方，还把年轻的汉献帝[2]放在自己身边，用皇帝[3]的名义[4]来指挥别人。在南方，孙权[5]接过了父亲和哥哥留下来的事业，占领[6]了长江[7]下游[8]的大片[9]地方。还有一个人叫刘备[10]，他说自己是汉朝[11]皇帝的后代[12]。他一开始没有土地，也没有多少军队[13]，只好到处投靠别人，可是他很会团结人，很多人都愿意跟着他。

5 后来，这三个人的力量慢慢变成了三个国家。公元 220 年，曹操[14]的儿子曹丕[15]当了皇帝，国号[16]叫魏[17]。第二年，刘备在成都[18]也当了皇帝，历史上叫蜀汉[19]，简称[20]蜀[21]。

1 控制 *kòngzhì* to control
2 汉献帝 *Hàn Xiàndì* Emperor Xian of Han, last Han emperor
3 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
4 名义 *míngyì* name, authority
5 孙权 *Sūn Quán* Sun Quan (182–252), ruler of Wu
6 占领 *zhànlǐng* to occupy
7 长江 *Cháng Jiāng* Yangtze River
8 下游 *xiàyóu* lower reaches
9 大片 *dàpiàn* large stretch
10 刘备 *Liú Bèi* Liu Bei (161–223), founder of Shu
11 汉朝 *Hàncháo* Han dynasty
12 后代 *hòudài* descendant
13 军队 *jūnduì* army
14 曹操 *Cáo Cāo* Cao Cao (155–220), warlord of the north
15 曹丕 *Cáo Pī* Cao Pi (187–226), first emperor of Wei
16 国号 *guóhào* dynastic name
17 魏 *Wèi* Wei (kingdom)
18 成都 *Chéngdū* Chengdu (city in Sichuan)
19 蜀汉 *Shǔ Hàn* Shu Han (221–263)
20 简称 *jiǎnchēng* abbreviated as
21 蜀 *Shǔ* Shu (kingdom)

He controlled the north and kept the young Emperor Xian of Han at his side, giving orders to others in the emperor's name. In the south, Sun Quan took over what his father and elder brother had built and held a large stretch of land along the lower Yangtze. There was also a man called Liu Bei, who said he was descended from the Han emperors. At first he had no land and few soldiers, and had to seek shelter with one lord after another; but he was very good at winning people over, and many were willing to follow him. 4

Over time, the forces of these three men turned into three states. In 220 AD Cao Cao's son Cao Pi became emperor and named his state Wei. The next year Liu Bei also made himself emperor, in Chengdu; historians call his state Shu Han, or Shu for short. 5

5 又过了几年，孙权[1]也当了皇帝[2]，国号[3]叫吴[4]。这就是“三国[5]”。

桃园结义[6]

6 《三国演义[7]》的故事是从三个人的友谊[8]开始的。小说里说，刘备[9]、关羽[10]和张飞[11]第一次见面，就觉得彼此[12]很合得来。张飞家后面有一个桃园[13]，那时正是桃花[14]开的时候。三个人就在桃园里摆上酒，对着天地[15]发誓[16]：从此以后就是兄弟，要一起帮助国家，一起保护老百姓，同生共死[17]。

1 孙权 *Sūn Quán* Sun Quan (182–252), ruler of Wu
2 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
3 国号 *guóhào* dynastic name
4 吴 *Wú* Wu (kingdom)
5 三国 *Sānguó* the Three Kingdoms
6 桃园结义 *Táoyuán jiéyì* the Peach Garden Oath
7 三国演义 *Sānguó Yǎnyì* Romance of the Three Kingdoms (novel)
8 友谊 *yǒuyì* friendship
9 刘备 *Liú Bèi* Liu Bei (161–223), founder of Shu
10 关羽 *Guān Yǔ* Guan Yu (d. 220), general of Shu
11 张飞 *Zhāng Fēi* Zhang Fei (d. 221), general of Shu
12 彼此 *bǐcǐ* each other
13 桃园 *táoyuán* peach orchard
14 桃花 *táohuā* peach blossom
15 天地 *tiāndì* heaven and earth
16 发誓 *fāshì* to swear an oath
17 同生共死 *tóngshēng gòngsǐ* to live and die together

A few years later Sun Quan too became emperor, of a state called Wu. These were the "Three Kingdoms". 5

The Peach Garden Oath

The story of Romance of the Three Kingdoms begins with the friendship of three men. According to the novel, when Liu Bei, Guan Yu and Zhang Fei first met, they felt at once that they got on very well. Behind Zhang Fei's house there was a peach orchard, and the peach trees were just then in blossom. So the three set out wine in the orchard and swore before heaven and earth that from then on they were brothers, who would help the country and protect the common people together, and live and die as one. 6

7 刘备[1]年纪最大，是大哥；关羽[2]是二哥；张飞[3]年纪最小，是三弟。在小说里，三兄弟的感情一直非常深。后来关羽被吴[4]国杀[5]了，不久张飞也死了。刘备不听别人的意见，一定要出兵为兄弟报仇[6]，结果打了一个大败仗[7]。

8 那么，历史上真的有“桃园结义[8]”吗？《三国志[9]》里没有他们发誓[10]结拜[11]的记录。不过，书里写到，刘备对关羽和张飞就像对自己的兄弟一样，三个人常常睡在同[12]一张床上。关羽和张飞也一直跟着刘备，对他非常忠心[13]。所以，三个人的关系确实很好，但是桃园[14]、喝酒、发誓这些细节，主要是后来的小说家想象出来的。

1 刘备 *Liú Bèi* Liu Bei (161–223), founder of Shu
2 关羽 *Guān Yǔ* Guan Yu (d. 220), general of Shu
3 张飞 *Zhāng Fēi* Zhang Fei (d. 221), general of Shu
4 吴 *Wú* Wu (kingdom)
5 杀 *shā* to kill
6 报仇 *bàochóu* to take revenge
7 败仗 *bàizhàng* defeat (in battle)
8 桃园结义 *Táoyuán jiéyì* the Peach Garden Oath
9 三国志 *Sānguó Zhì* Records of the Three Kingdoms (history)
10 发誓 *fāshì* to swear an oath
11 结拜 *jiébài* to become sworn brothers
12 同 *tóng* same
13 忠心 *zhōngxīn* loyal
14 桃园 *táoyuán* peach orchard

Liu Bei was the oldest, so he was the eldest brother; Guan Yu was the second; 7
Zhang Fei, the youngest, was the third. In the novel, the bond between the three brothers stays deep throughout. Later Guan Yu was killed by Wu, and soon afterwards Zhang Fei died too. Liu Bei ignored all advice and insisted on sending his army to avenge his brothers, and in the end he suffered a crushing defeat.

So was there really a "Peach Garden Oath" in history? The Records of the 8
Three Kingdoms contain no account of them swearing brotherhood. The book does say, however, that Liu Bei treated Guan Yu and Zhang Fei like his own brothers, and that the three often slept in the same bed. Guan Yu and Zhang Fei followed Liu Bei all their lives and were utterly loyal to him. So the three really were close; but the orchard, the wine and the oath are details mostly imagined by later storytellers.

三顾茅庐[1]

刘备[2]有了好兄弟，可是还缺一个能帮他出主意的人。有人告诉他，在隆中[3]住着一个年轻人，叫诸葛亮[4]，非常有才能。刘备就带着关羽[5]和张飞[6]去请他。小说里，第一次去，诸葛亮不在家；第二次去，天上正下着大雪，诸葛亮又出门了。张飞很不耐烦[7]，说不如用绳子[8]把他绑[9]来。刘备却不同意，第三次又去了。这一次，诸葛亮正在睡觉，刘备不让人叫醒他，就在门外安静地等着，一直等到他醒来。

诸葛亮被刘备的诚意[10]感动了。两个人谈了很久，诸葛亮给刘备分析[11]了天下[12]的形势：

1 三顾茅庐 *sān gù máolú* three visits to the thatched cottage
2 刘备 *Liú Bèi* Liu Bei (161–223), founder of Shu
3 隆中 *Lóngzhōng* Longzhong (near today's Xiangyang)
4 诸葛亮 *Zhūgě Liàng* Zhuge Liang (181–234), strategist and chancellor of Shu
5 关羽 *Guān Yǔ* Guan Yu (d. 220), general of Shu
6 张飞 *Zhāng Fēi* Zhang Fei (d. 221), general of Shu
7 耐烦 *nàifán* impatient
8 绳子 *shéngzi* rope
9 绑 *bǎng* to tie up
10 诚意 *chéngyì* sincerity
11 分析 *fēnxī* to analyse
12 天下 *tiānxià* the whole country

Three Visits to the Thatched Cottage

Liu Bei now had good brothers, but he still lacked someone who could ad- 9
vise him. Someone told him that a young man called Zhuge Liang, who was extremely talented, lived at Longzhong. So Liu Bei took Guan Yu and Zhang Fei and went to invite him. In the novel, the first time they went, Zhuge Liang was not at home; the second time, in heavy snow, he had gone out again. Zhang Fei lost patience and said they might as well tie him up with a rope and bring him back. But Liu Bei would not hear of it, and went a third time. This time Zhuge Liang was asleep; Liu Bei would not let anyone wake him, and waited quietly outside the door until he woke.

Zhuge Liang was moved by Liu Bei's sincerity. The two talked for a long 10
time, and Zhuge Liang analysed the situation of the whole country for Liu Bei:

10 北方的曹操[1]太强大，不能马上跟他打；东边的孙权[2]也很稳定，应该跟他联合；刘备[3]可以先占领[4]荆州[5]和益州[6]，再慢慢发展。这次谈话后来被叫做《隆中对[7]》。从此以后，诸葛亮[8]就成了刘备最重要的助手[9]。

11 这个故事大部分是真的。《三国志[10]》里清楚地写着，刘备一共去了三次，才见到诸葛亮。诸葛亮自己后来在一篇文章里也说过，刘备曾经三次到他的草房来看他。不过，下大雪、在门外等他睡醒这些情节[11]，是小说加上去的，为了让故事更感人[12]。今天，“三顾茅庐[13]”已经成了一个成语[14]，意思是真心[15]地一次又一次去请有才能的人。

1 曹操 *Cáo Cāo* Cao Cao (155–220), warlord of the north
2 孙权 *Sūn Quán* Sun Quan (182–252), ruler of Wu
3 刘备 *Liú Bèi* Liu Bei (161–223), founder of Shu
4 占领 *zhànlǐng* to occupy
5 荆州 *Jīngzhōu* Jing province (central China)
6 益州 *Yìzhōu* Yi province (today's Sichuan)
7 隆中对 *Lóngzhōng Duì* the Longzhong Plan
8 诸葛亮 *Zhūgě Liàng* Zhuge Liang (181–234), strategist and chancellor of Shu
9 助手 *zhùshǒu* helper, assistant
10 三国志 *Sānguó Zhì* Records of the Three Kingdoms (history)
11 情节 *qíngjié* plot details
12 感人 *gǎnrén* moving
13 三顾茅庐 *sān gù máolú* three visits to the thatched cottage
14 成语 *chéngyǔ* idiom
15 真心 *zhēnxīn* sincere

Cao Cao in the north was too strong to fight straight away; Sun Quan in the east was firmly established and should be made an ally; Liu Bei should first take Jing and Yi provinces, and then grow step by step. This conversation later became known as the Longzhong Plan. From then on Zhuge Liang was Liu Bei's most important helper. 10

Most of this story is true. The Records of the Three Kingdoms state clearly that Liu Bei went three times before he got to see Zhuge Liang. Zhuge Liang himself later wrote, in one of his own essays, that Liu Bei had come to his thatched hut three times. The heavy snow and the waiting at the door until he woke, however, were added by the novel to make the story more moving. Today "three visits to the thatched cottage" is an idiom meaning to invite a talented person sincerely, again and again. 11

赤壁之战[1]

12 公元208年，曹操[2]统一了北方以后，带着大军[3]向南方进攻[4]，想一次打败刘备[5]和孙权[6]。刘备的力量很小，只好派诸葛亮[7]去见孙权，请他一起对抗[8]曹操。孙权手下有人主张投降[9]，可是大将军[10]周瑜[11]认为，曹军[12][13]虽然人多，但是北方的士兵不习惯坐船，也不适应南方的气候，完全可以打败。孙权最后决定和刘备联合。

13 两边的军队[14]在长江[15]边的赤壁[16]相遇[17]。曹操的船很多，一条接一条，连在一起。吴[18]国的老将军黄盖[19]看到了这个机会，提出用火来进攻。

1 赤壁之战 *Chìbì zhī zhàn* Battle of Red Cliffs (208)
2 曹操 *Cáo Cāo* Cao Cao (155–220), warlord of the north
3 大军 *dàjūn* great army
4 进攻 *jìngōng* to attack
5 刘备 *Liú Bèi* Liu Bei (161–223), founder of Shu
6 孙权 *Sūn Quán* Sun Quan (182–252), ruler of Wu
7 诸葛亮 *Zhūgě Liàng* Zhuge Liang (181–234), strategist and chancellor of Shu
8 对抗 *duìkàng* to resist
9 投降 *tóuxiáng* to surrender
10 将军 *jiāngjūn* general
11 周瑜 *Zhōu Yú* Zhou Yu (175–210), commander of Wu
12 曹 *Cáo* Cao (Cao Cao's)
13 军 *jūn* army
14 军队 *jūnduì* army
15 长江 *Cháng Jiāng* Yangtze River
16 赤壁 *Chìbì* Red Cliffs (on the Yangtze)
17 相遇 *xiāngyù* to meet
18 吴 *Wú* Wu (kingdom)
19 黄盖 *Huáng Gài* Huang Gai, veteran general of Wu

The Battle of Red Cliffs

In 208 AD, having united the north, Cao Cao led a great army south, hoping 12
to defeat Liu Bei and Sun Quan in one campaign. Liu Bei's forces were small, so he sent Zhuge Liang to see Sun Quan and ask him to stand against Cao Cao together. Some of Sun Quan's advisers urged surrender, but the great general Zhou Yu argued that although Cao Cao's army was large, northern soldiers were not used to boats or to the southern climate, and could certainly be beaten. In the end Sun Quan decided to join forces with Liu Bei.

The two sides met at Red Cliffs, on the bank of the Yangtze. Cao Cao had a 13
great many ships, moored one after another and joined together. Huang Gai, a veteran general of Wu, saw his chance and proposed an attack with fire.

13 他假装[1]向曹操[2]投降[3]，带着几十条装满干草和油的船开向曹[4]军[5]。快到的时候，士兵们点上火，那时正刮[6]着大风，着火的船一直冲进了曹军的船队。连在一起的船来不及分开，很快就烧成了一片火海。再加上[7]军中很多人生病，曹操大败，只好回到北方。从此，三方的力量都不能消灭[8]对方，三国[9]的局面[10]基本形成了。

14 在《三国演义[11]》里，赤壁之战[12]最大的英雄[13]是诸葛亮[14]。小说里有一个很有名的故事，叫“草船借箭[15]”。周瑜[16]想害[17]诸葛亮，故意让他在十天里做出十万支箭[18]。诸葛亮却说三天就够了。

1 假装 *jiǎzhuāng* to pretend
2 曹操 *Cáo Cāo* Cao Cao (155–220), warlord of the north
3 投降 *tóuxiáng* to surrender
4 曹 *Cáo* Cao (Cao Cao's)
5 军 *jūn* army
6 刮 *guā* to blow (wind)
7 加上 *jiāshàng* in addition
8 消灭 *xiāomiè* to wipe out
9 三国 *Sānguó* the Three Kingdoms
10 局面 *júmiàn* situation, balance
11 三国演义 *Sānguó Yǎnyì* Romance of the Three Kingdoms (novel)
12 赤壁之战 *Chìbì zhī zhàn* Battle of Red Cliffs (208)
13 英雄 *yīngxióng* hero
14 诸葛亮 *Zhūgě Liàng* Zhuge Liang (181–234), strategist and chancellor of Shu
15 草船借箭 *cǎo chuán jiè jiàn* borrowing arrows with straw boats
16 周瑜 *Zhōu Yú* Zhou Yu (175–210), commander of Wu
17 害 *hài* to harm
18 箭 *jiàn* arrow

He pretended to surrender to Cao Cao and sailed towards his fleet with dozens 13
of boats loaded with dry grass and oil. As they drew near, the soldiers set them alight; a strong wind was blowing, and the burning boats drove straight into Cao Cao's fleet. The ships, chained together, could not separate in time, and soon the whole fleet was a sea of flames. With many of his soldiers also sick, Cao Cao was utterly defeated and had to return north. From then on none of the three sides could wipe out the others, and the three-way division was more or less settled.

In Romance of the Three Kingdoms, the greatest hero of Red Cliffs is Zhuge 14
Liang. The novel has a famous story called "borrowing arrows with straw boats". Zhou Yu, wanting to get rid of Zhuge Liang, deliberately ordered him to produce a hundred thousand arrows in ten days. Zhuge Liang, however, said three days would be enough.

14 第三天早上，江上起了大雾[1]，他让人在二十条船上绑[2]满稻草[3]，开到曹[4]军[5]前面，再让士兵们大声喊叫。曹操[6]怕雾[7]里有埋伏[8]，不敢出来，只让士兵向船上射[9]箭[10]。雾散了以后，船上的稻草插[11]满了箭，一共有十几万支。诸葛亮[12]笑着回去了。

15 小说里还说，火攻[13]需要东风，是诸葛亮用法术“借”来的。这些都不是历史。历史上，指挥赤壁之战[14]的是周瑜[15]，用火进攻[16]的主意是黄盖[17]提出来的。而且，历史上的周瑜心胸[18]很宽，并不像小说里那样小气[19]。至于用船[20]“借箭”，历史上没有诸葛亮做过这件事的记录。

1 大雾 *dàwù* thick fog
2 绑 *bǎng* to tie up
3 稻草 *dàocǎo* rice straw
4 曹 *Cáo* Cao (Cao Cao's)
5 军 *jūn* army
6 曹操 *Cáo Cāo* Cao Cao (155–220), warlord of the north
7 雾 *wù* fog
8 埋伏 *máifu* ambush
9 射 *shè* to shoot
10 箭 *jiàn* arrow
11 插 *chā* to stick in
12 诸葛亮 *Zhūgě Liàng* Zhuge Liang (181–234), strategist and chancellor of Shu
13 火攻 *huǒgōng* fire attack
14 赤壁之战 *Chìbì zhī zhàn* Battle of Red Cliffs (208)
15 周瑜 *Zhōu Yú* Zhou Yu (175–210), commander of Wu
16 进攻 *jìngōng* to attack
17 黄盖 *Huáng Gài* Huang Gai, veteran general of Wu
18 心胸 *xīnxiōng* breadth of mind
19 小气 *xiǎoqi* petty
20 至于 *zhìyú* as for

On the morning of the third day thick fog lay on the river. He had twenty 14
boats covered in bundles of straw, sailed them up to Cao Cao's camp, and had the soldiers shout at the top of their voices. Afraid of an ambush in the fog, Cao Cao dared not come out, and only had his men shoot arrows at the boats. When the fog lifted, the straw was bristling with arrows, more than a hundred thousand of them. Zhuge Liang went back smiling.

The novel also says that the fire attack needed an east wind, and that Zhuge 15
Liang "borrowed" it by magic. None of this is history. In history it was Zhou Yu who commanded at Red Cliffs, and the idea of attacking with fire came from Huang Gai. What is more, the historical Zhou Yu was a generous-minded man, not at all as petty as the novel makes him. As for "borrowing arrows" with boats, there is no historical record of Zhuge Liang ever doing it.

15 有一本古书记录过一个有点像的故事，主人公[1]却是孙权[2]：他的船一边中了太多箭[3]，快要翻了，他就让船转过来，用另[4]一边接箭，船就又平了。

空城计[5]

16 刘备[6]死后，诸葛亮[7]帮助刘备的儿子刘禅[8]管理蜀国[9]，还好几次带兵向北进攻[10]魏国[11]。小说里写到这样一个故事：有一次，蜀[12]军[13]丢[14]了一个重要的地方，魏国的大将军[15]司马懿[16]带着十五万大军[17]，向诸葛亮所在[18]的小城冲来。那时，城里只有两千多个士兵，大部分军队[19]都不在身边，想走也来不及了。

1 主人公 *zhǔréngōng* protagonist
2 孙权 *Sūn Quán* Sun Quan (182–252), ruler of Wu
3 箭 *jiàn* arrow
4 另 *lìng* another
5 空城计 *kōngchéngjì* the empty fort strategy
6 刘备 *Liú Bèi* Liu Bei (161–223), founder of Shu
7 诸葛亮 *Zhūgě Liàng* Zhuge Liang (181–234), strategist and chancellor of Shu
8 刘禅 *Liú Shàn* Liu Shan (207–271), second ruler of Shu
9 蜀国 *Shǔguó* the state of Shu
10 进攻 *jìngōng* to attack
11 魏国 *Wèiguó* the state of Wei
12 蜀 *Shǔ* Shu (kingdom)
13 军 *jūn* army
14 丢 *diū* to lose
15 将军 *jiāngjūn* general
16 司马懿 *Sīmǎ Yì* Sima Yi (179–251), general of Wei
17 大军 *dàjūn* great army
18 所在 *suǒzài* where (sb) is
19 军队 *jūnduì* army

An old book records a somewhat similar story, but its hero is Sun Quan: one side of his boat was hit by so many arrows that it was about to capsize, so he had the boat turned round to take arrows on the other side, and it righted itself. 15

The Empty Fort Strategy

After Liu Bei's death, Zhuge Liang helped Liu Bei's son Liu Shan govern Shu, and several times led armies north against Wei. The novel tells this story: once, after the Shu army had lost an important position, Sima Yi, the great general of Wei, came charging with 150,000 men towards the small town where Zhuge Liang was. There were only some two thousand soldiers in the town; most of the army was elsewhere, and it was too late to get away. 16

17 诸葛亮[1]想了一个大胆[2]的办法。他让人把四个城门都打开，每个门口只有二十个士兵，打扮[3]成老百姓的样子，低着头慢慢地扫地。他自己坐在城墙上，点上香，安静地弹[4]琴[5]，看起来非常轻松。司马懿[6]来到城下，看到这个样子，反而不敢进城了。他知道诸葛亮一向[7]非常小心，从来不冒险[8]，就怀疑城里有埋伏[9]，马上命令[10]军队[11]退了回去。就这样，诸葛亮用一座空城吓[12]走了十几万大军[13]。

18 这个故事是《三国演义[14]》里最精彩的情节[15]之一，可是它几乎可以肯定[16]不是真的。

1 诸葛亮 *Zhūgě Liàng* Zhuge Liang (181–234), strategist and chancellor of Shu
2 大胆 *dàdǎn* bold
3 打扮 *dǎban* to dress up
4 弹 *tán* to play (a string instrument)
5 琴 *qín* qin (zither)
6 司马懿 *Sīmǎ Yì* Sima Yi (179–251), general of Wei
7 一向 *yīxiàng* always, consistently
8 冒险 *màoxiǎn* to take risks
9 埋伏 *máifu* ambush
10 命令 *mìnglìng* to order
11 军队 *jūnduì* army
12 吓 *xià* to frighten
13 大军 *dàjūn* great army
14 三国演义 *Sānguó Yǎnyì* Romance of the Three Kingdoms (novel)
15 情节 *qíngjié* plot details
16 肯定 *kěndìng* to be sure

Zhuge Liang came up with a bold plan. He had all four city gates thrown open, with only twenty soldiers at each, dressed as ordinary townsfolk and calmly sweeping the ground with their heads down. He himself sat on the city wall, lit some incense, and played the zither quietly, looking completely at ease. When Sima Yi reached the town and saw this, he did not dare to go in. He knew that Zhuge Liang was always very cautious and never took risks, so he suspected an ambush in the town and at once ordered his army to pull back. And so, with an empty town, Zhuge Liang frightened away an army of more than a hundred thousand. 17

This is one of the most thrilling episodes in Romance of the Three Kingdoms, but it is almost certainly not true. 18

18 早在一千五百多年前，给《三国志[1]》写注释的学者[2]裴松之[3]就已经指出，那时司马懿[4]根本不在那里，所以这件事不可能发生。小说家把它写进书里，是为了表现诸葛亮[5]的聪明[6]和冷静。有意思的是，“空城计[7]”后来变得非常有名，人们常用它来说明一种做法：自己力量不够的时候，故意表现得很冷静，让对方不敢行动。

三国[8]故事的今天

19 三国时代早就结束了。公元 263 年，魏国[9]灭[10]了蜀国[11]。两年以后，魏国的大臣[12]司马炎[13]夺[14]走了皇帝的位子[15][16]，建立了晋朝[17]。

1 三国志 *Sānguó Zhì* Records of the Three Kingdoms (history)
2 学者 *xuézhě* scholar
3 裴松之 *Péi Sōngzhī* Pei Songzhi (372–451), historian
4 司马懿 *Sīmǎ Yì* Sima Yi (179–251), general of Wei
5 诸葛亮 *Zhūgě Liàng* Zhuge Liang (181–234), strategist and chancellor of Shu
6 聪明 *cōngming* cleverness
7 空城计 *kōngchéngjì* the empty fort strategy
8 三国 *Sānguó* the Three Kingdoms
9 魏国 *Wèiguó* the state of Wei
10 灭 *miè* to destroy
11 蜀国 *Shǔguó* the state of Shu
12 大臣 *dàchén* minister
13 司马炎 *Sīmǎ Yán* Sima Yan (236–290), first emperor of Jin
14 夺 *duó* to seize
15 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
16 位子 *wèizi* seat, throne
17 晋朝 *Jìncháo* Jin dynasty

As early as fifteen hundred years ago, the scholar Pei Songzhi, who wrote a commentary on the Records of the Three Kingdoms, pointed out that Sima Yi was not even in that place at the time, so the event could not have happened. The novelist wrote it into the book to show Zhuge Liang's cleverness and composure. Interestingly, "the empty fort strategy" later became a well-known expression for a particular trick: when you are weak, you deliberately act calm so that your opponent dare not move. 18

The Three Kingdoms Today

The Three Kingdoms era ended long ago. In 263 AD Wei conquered Shu. Two years later Sima Yan, a minister of Wei, seized the throne and founded the Jin dynasty. 19

19 280 年，晋朝[1]又灭[2]了吴国[3]，中国重新统一了。可是，三国[4]的故事一直流传到了今天。

20 很多三国故事变成了成语[5]和俗语[6]。比如，“三顾茅庐[7]”表示真心[8]地邀请[9]人才；“说曹操[10]，曹操到”，意思是刚说到某个人，这个人就出现了。还有一句俗语说：三个普通人一起想办法，就能比得上一个诸葛亮[11]。

21 三国人物[12]也常常出现在京剧和各种地方戏[13]里。关羽[14]因为忠诚[15]和勇敢，后来被人们当作[16]神[17]来尊敬[18]，很多地方都有关公[19]庙[20]，有的商店里也放着关公像。

1 晋朝 *Jìncháo* Jin dynasty
2 灭 *miè* to destroy
3 吴国 *Wúguó* the state of Wu
4 三国 *Sānguó* the Three Kingdoms
5 成语 *chéngyǔ* idiom
6 俗语 *súyǔ* common saying
7 三顾茅庐 *sān gù máolú* three visits to the thatched cottage
8 真心 *zhēnxīn* sincere
9 邀请 *yāoqǐng* to invite
10 曹操 *Cáo Cāo* Cao Cao (155–220), warlord of the north
11 诸葛亮 *Zhūgě Liàng* Zhuge Liang (181–234), strategist and chancellor of Shu
12 人物 *rénwù* characters, figures
13 戏 *xì* opera (genre)
14 关羽 *Guān Yǔ* Guan Yu (d. 220), general of Shu
15 忠诚 *zhōngchéng* loyalty
16 当作 *dàngzuò* to regard as
17 神 *shén* god
18 尊敬 *zūnjìng* to honour
19 关公 *Guān Gōng* Lord Guan (Guan Yu as a god)
20 庙 *miào* temple

In 280 Jin conquered Wu as well, and China was united again. But the stories 19
of the Three Kingdoms have been handed down to this day.

Many Three Kingdoms stories have turned into idioms and sayings. For ex- 20
ample, "three visits to the thatched cottage" means sincerely inviting talented people; "speak of Cao Cao and Cao Cao arrives" means that someone turns up just as you mention them. Another saying goes that three ordinary people thinking together can match one Zhuge Liang.

Three Kingdoms characters also appear again and again in Peking opera and 21
many regional operas. Because of his loyalty and courage, Guan Yu later came to be worshipped as a god; there are temples to Lord Guan in many places, and some shops keep a statue of him.

21 到了现代，三国[1]故事又被拍成了电视剧和电影，还做成了漫画[2]和电子游戏。在日本、韩国[3]和越南，三国故事也很受欢迎，很多外国年轻人就是通过游戏第一次认识了曹操[4]、刘备[5]和诸葛亮[6]。

结语

22 读三国的时候，我们最好记住两本书：《三国志》[7]告诉我们历史上发生了什么，《三国演义》[8]告诉我们人们希望历史是什么样子。小说里的诸葛亮几乎什么都知道，曹操是坏人，刘备是好人；历史上的人物[9]却要复杂得多。也许，正是历史和故事之间的这种差别[10]，让三国到今天还这么吸引人。

1 三国 *Sānguó* the Three Kingdoms
2 漫画 *mànhuà* comics
3 韩国 *Hánguó* Korea
4 曹操 *Cáo Cāo* Cao Cao (155–220), warlord of the north
5 刘备 *Liú Bèi* Liu Bei (161–223), founder of Shu
6 诸葛亮 *Zhūgě Liàng* Zhuge Liang (181–234), strategist and chancellor of Shu
7 三国志 *Sānguó Zhì* Records of the Three Kingdoms (history)
8 三国演义 *Sānguó Yǎnyì* Romance of the Three Kingdoms (novel)
9 人物 *rénwù* characters, figures
10 差别 *chābié* difference

In modern times the stories have been made into TV series and films, and into comics and video games too. The stories are popular in Japan, Korea and Vietnam as well, and many young people abroad first meet Cao Cao, Liu Bei and Zhuge Liang through games. 21

In Closing

When we read about the Three Kingdoms, it is best to keep two books in mind: the Records tell us what happened, and the Romance tells us what people wished had happened. In the novel Zhuge Liang knows almost everything, Cao Cao is the villain and Liu Bei the good man; the real people were far more complicated. Perhaps it is exactly this gap between history and story that keeps the Three Kingdoms so fascinating today. 22